ʿIrfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

Based on a lecture series by
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An invitation

وَأَنِرْ أَبْصَارَ قُلُوبِنَا بِضِيَاءِ نَظَرِهَا إِلَيْكَ حَتَّىٰ تَخْرِقَ أَبْصَارُ الْقُلُوبِ حُجُبَ النُّورِ فَتَصِلَ إِلَىٰ مَعْدِنِ الْعَظَمَةِ

Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of their looking at You to the extent that they penetrate the veils of light and reach the Source of Grandeur.[1]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

What is ʿirfan?

These words come from the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, a prayer many of us recite in the month of Shaʿban. The line asks God to light up the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at Him, until those eyes pass through even the veils of light and reach the source of His grandeur. It is a request to see God with the heart and to be near Him. Requests like this one were written for us, by the Imams (ʿa), as an endeavour for the ordinary believer.

Despite saying these words in our munajats and on auspicious occasions, we find that seeking to know God does not feature in our day-to-day routine. Praying, fasting and paying what is due, the *wajibat*, are the dominant undertaking, and they are what most of us mean by practising the religion. The other side, the one the Munajat describes, in which the believer seeks to know God

[1] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

and to come near Him, is often less practised. That side of the religion is called *ʿirfan*.

ʿIrfan is the Arabic name for what English books call Islamic mysticism, and the two words do not say the same thing. "Mysticism" suggests mystery, something hidden and hard to pin down. The Arabic word names a kind of knowing. It shares its root with *maʿrifah*, knowledge, and an *ʿarif* is, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "someone who knows".

The knowing meant here is not information about God. It is knowing Him from close, with the heart, which is what the Munajat asks for. In Murtada Mutahhari's words, the ʿarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[2]. ʿIrfan is that knowing, and the training of the soul that makes it possible. It is part of the Islam we already know: its sources are the Qur'an and the words of the Imams, and the prayer at the head of this page is one of them.

This book argues that this side of the religion is worth every believer's pursuit. ʿIrfan travels through the self and never leaves the shariʿa. It is walked by a tested and ordered method. It is rooted in the Qur'an and the Imams. And it ends not in withdrawal from the world but in return: to people, with God, and to God Himself.

Who this book is for

The argument is addressed to anyone who prays, fasts and recites the duʿas, and who has wondered whether there is more to these acts than getting them right; whether the religion has another dimension. No knowledge of ʿirfan, of philosophy or of Arabic is assumed. The book is meant as a welcoming introduction to ʿirfan, a guide to beginning the journey that strives for brevity and clarity. Each chapter opens with a section that details some of the words you'll meet, along with an explanation; all terms are gathered in the glossary at the end. Additional call-out sections are spread throughout with helpful context and short side notes.

[2]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

How the book is built

The book is built in five parts. Each answers one question and depends on the one before.

Part One, *The Call* (Chapters 1–3), asks why a believer should bother. It answers that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. The goal of ʿirfan is already on our lips in our duʿas.

Part Two, *Getting Ready* (Chapters 4–7), describes the landscape a traveller passes through on the journey towards ʿirfan: the self. It also sets out the boundary that keeps the traveller safe, the shariʿa, and the guide who walks alongside.

Part Three, *The Road* (Chapters 8–12), asks how the path is walked: through ordered stages, by repentance, discipline and love, to the loss of the false self.

Part Four, *Fellow Travellers* (Chapters 13–15), meets those who walked the road before us. It shows the road's roots in the Qur'an and the Imams, where its travellers arrived, and how Shia ʿirfan relates to Sufism.

Part Five, *The Destination* (Chapters 16–17), asks what the road is for. The friends of God return to people, with God; every soul returns to God.

Where this book comes from

This book is inspired by a lecture series on Islamic mysticism given by Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour. The content and structure of those lectures are the core of the book. Wherever the Sheikh is quoted directly, the words are his own, from that series.

Turning spoken lectures into a book has called for some editorial adaptation. To suit a wider readership, the book also adds context and explanation to support its main arguments. It draws on a wider literature as well: the words of the Imams in Nahj al-Balagha, al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya and the supplications of the Mafatih; then the great Shia teachers of the path, from Sayyid Haydar Amuli in the fourteenth century to modern scholars such as Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, ʿAllama Tabataba'i, Imam Khomeini and Ayatullah Mutahhari. Every source is given in a footnote, for readers who want to go further.

The finer questions of ʿirfan remain an ongoing conversation among our *ʿulama'*: whether a seeker needs a guide from the first step, how much solitude is wise, how far ordinary believers can travel. Where they differ, this book presents each view with neutrality.

What you can expect

Three guiding principles frame the discussions in the chapters that follow. The first is that ʿirfan is never pursued for the sake of powers, such as reading minds or foreseeing future events. Sheikh Bahmanpour and the wider literature agree on this, as Chapter 1 shows.

The second is that there is no separate sect or order through which ʿirfan must be gained. Shia ʿirfan has no institution of authority beside the Imam. How this position differs from that of the Sufi orders is explored in Chapter 15.

The third principle is the most important: no part of the journey towards ʿirfan requires stepping outside the shariʿa, and nothing on that journey is gained by doing so. The beginning of ʿirfan, as the Sheikh puts it, is the shariʿa. The inner path does not go around the law or rise above it; it is the law lived from the inside. Nothing in this book asks a reader to set aside the rulings of the jurists or the guidance of their marjaʿ. A fear that mysticism might do exactly that is one reason some scholars have been wary of ʿirfan. Chapter 14 sets out their wider concerns, with the answers given to them.

By the end, a reader should feel able to say what ʿirfan is and is not, why it belongs to us, and what the stages and dangers of the path entail. For those who wish to go further, each chapter and the epilogue offer small, practical steps for bringing this into daily life alongside the wajibat.

PART ONE

The Call

Why travel?

The Qur’an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. That knowing is reached by purifying the heart, and our own prayers already ask for it.

1 · More than the minimum
2 · Knowing about God is not knowing Him
3 · You already know these words

إِلٰهِي لَمْ يَكُنْ لِي حَوْلٌ فَأَنْتَقِلَ بِهِ عَنْ مَعْصِيَتِكَ إِلاَّ فِي وَقْتٍ أَيْقَظْتَنِي لِمَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, I was not strong enough to move away from Your disobedience, except when You awakened me to Your love.

Munajat Sha‘baniyyah

1

More than the minimum

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.

Qur'an 30:21

There is a verse often recited at weddings, one most of us know. In Surah al-Rum, God says that He created spouses for us from among ourselves "that you may take comfort in them", and that He ordained "affection and mercy" between husband and wife (Q 30:21). The verse ends with the words above: this is a sign for a people who reflect. Whether a person sees it depends on something in the person doing the looking. That something, and why it is worth developing, is the subject of this chapter.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *'Irfan*: knowing God from close · *ma'rifah*: knowledge of God · *'arif* (plural *'urafa'*): one who knows God · *muqarrabun*: those brought near to God · *awliya' Allah*: the friends of God · *shirk*: setting up a partner beside God

What the minimum leaves out

Let's start with two claims. The first is that a believer who prays, fasts, pays what is due and goes on hajj can hope for *jannah*, provided they do what is *wajib* and avoid what is forbidden. This claim is not contested. Sheikh Bahmanpour accepts it as fair for ordinary believers. Mohammad Ali Shomali makes the same point, describing the obligatory rules of fiqh as "the minimally necessary conditions of human perfection"[3].

The second claim goes further, and it is the one this book disputes. Some jurists and activists hold that the obligatory acts are the whole of the religion; anything beyond them, they say, is made up by the whims and wishes of certain mystics.

To see why there is more than the obligations, let's turn to the Qur'an and read on from the verse this chapter began with. Surah al-Rum names three more sets of signs: the creation of the heavens and the earth, with the variety of our languages and colours; our sleep and our work; the lightning, and the rain that revives the dead earth (Q 30:22–24). Each verse ends as the first did, by saying who the sign is for.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالِمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

There are indeed signs in that for those who know.

Qur'an 30:22

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who listen.

Qur'an 30:23

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

There are indeed signs in that for people who exercise their reason.

Qur'an 30:24

[3]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 17.

Four times in a row, the Qur'an makes the same point. The signs are all around us: in marriage, in the people we meet, in sleep, in work, in the weather. Yet they are for those who reflect, know, listen and reason. This reflecting, knowing, listening and reasoning is what the Qur'an asks of us beyond the minimum.

For the avoidance of doubt, this invitation from the Qur'an is not an invitation to circumvent the law or to abandon the prescribed wajibat. Imam Khomeini insists that a genuine seeker's devotion "is within the bounds of the Shari'ah"[4]. Within those bounds, the Qur'an is just as insistent, in these verses and others, that it invites us to more than the obligatory acts.

Signs most people miss

An invitation addressed to those who reflect, know, listen and reason implies that many people do none of these things. Sheikh Bahmanpour does not limit this to the careless. Most pious people, he says, even those careful about the shariʿa, do not find a sign in these verses. Looking at the variety of languages and colours, we are more likely to see a reason for division than a sign of God.

We have heard these verses many times, and we accept that there are signs in them because the Qur'an says so; yet accepting that a sign exists is not the same as perceiving it. The Qur'an describes the gap in one verse.

وَكَأَيِّن مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ ﴿١٠٥﴾

How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass by while they are disregardful of it!

Qur'an 12:105

ʿAllama Tabataba'i explains what passing by a sign means; a person who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and "what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator"[5]. Most of us see only the lamp. We witness the rain as rain and the marriage as a marriage, and we pass them by without perceiving what they say about their Creator.

[4]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

[5]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.

The fault is in the receiver

If the signs are present and plain, and yet we still pass them by, the fault is on our side. The Qur'an says where it lies, speaking of people who have every faculty and use none of them.

لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَّا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَّا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ ءَاذَانٌ لَّا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَآ
أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ كَٱلْأَنْعَٰمِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ

they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray.

Qur'an 7:179

Cattle see and hear perfectly well, so the comparison cannot be about the senses. Sheikh Bahmanpour reads it as being about what lies behind the senses. Eyes and ears take in the surface of things, whereas inside a human being there should be something more: a faculty, which animals lack, that turns what the senses take in into understanding. In most of us, he says, it is not working.

He compares this faculty to a machine. The ear catches the sound, but "there is something inside which doesn't catch it. There is a machine inside which is [rusted]." That machine is the soul. It has to be repaired before it can catch the signals of God. For Sheikh Bahmanpour, this is the whole subject in one sentence: mysticism is about making the soul hear, see and reflect. He adds that this is not easy, and requires a great deal of training.

Placing the fault in the receiver has two consequences. The first is that the problem is not a shortage of evidence. God is not withholding signs; we are failing to receive them.

The second is that the problem can be solved. A faculty that exists but has rusted can be repaired; one that is absent cannot be made fit for purpose. The *Kernel of the Kernels*, a record of 'Allama Tabataba'i's early lectures on the path, opens by saying that the pull towards the unseen is "part of the innate instincts of the human being"[6]. The longing for God, and the faculty that perceives Him, are part of how we are made.

[6] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 4.

Repair is only the start. Once the inner faculty begins to work, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, the journey begins, and it does not end; it is a path that “has a beginning and no end”.

Some do see

If the faculty can be repaired, there should be people in whom it already works. The Qur’an describes them more than once. Sheikh Bahmanpour divides people into two groups: those whose souls work, and those whose souls do not. He calls the first group the *‘urafa’*, the plural of *‘arif*. He sets the prophets and the Imams (‘a) aside as a class of their own, and looks at ordinary believers who see more than the rest. The first description of them is in Surah al-Anfal.

إِنَّمَا ٱلْمُؤْمِنُونَ ٱلَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ ٱللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned,

Qur’an 8:2

A heart trembles only at the mention of someone it has some experience of; a name means little to a person who does not know whom it names. The believers of this verse are thus the believers who know Allah. A verse in Surah Al ‘Imran goes further, giving them another name.

شَهِدَ ٱللَّهُ أَنَّهُۥ لَآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَٱلْمَلَٰٓئِكَةُ وَأُو۟لُوا۟ ٱلْعِلْمِ

Allah ... bears witness that there is no god except Him, and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge.

Qur’an 3:18

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads “those who possess knowledge” as another name for the ‘urafa’. Every Muslim knows that there is no god but Allah. Our knowledge of *tawhid*, God’s oneness, is still not the knowledge of those who witness it. Tawhid is simple to say and hard to grasp; in the Sheikh’s view, the intellect alone cannot reach its depths, and only the awakened soul can. Surah Fatir describes the same people by what they feel.

إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى ٱللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ ٱلْعُلَمَٰٓؤُا۟

Only those of Allah's servants having knowledge fear Him.

Qur'an 35:28

Most of us fear Allah's punishment. The people of this verse fear Him with a fear that is not about punishment at all.

Surah Yunus adds to their names, which Sheikh Bahmanpour treats as the same people: the *awliya' Allah*, the friends of God (Q 10:62). Imam ʿAli (ʿa) describes what these friends see that others miss.

God's special devotees are those who perceive the world's reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.[7]

Nahj al-Balagha

Other people look at the surface of the world; the friends of God look at what lies inside it. Sheikh Bahmanpour is careful about what this means. There is nothing wrong with pursuing material wealth in this life; the trouble is being solely occupied with it. The friends of God have families, friends and a place in society, as we do. They think not about themselves but about God, and in their hearts they are cut off from everything else.

What they are given, and why it is open to all

The Qur'an also tells us what these people receive. The first gift is nearness: Surah al-Waqiʿa sorts people on the Last Day, and at the top it places the Foremost Ones.

وَٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ﴿١٠﴾ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ ٱلْمُقَرَّبُونَ ﴿١١﴾

And the Foremost Ones are the foremost ones: they are the ones brought near [to Allah],

Qur'an 56:10-11

[7] Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.

The Arabic for “brought near” is *muqarrabun*. God is not far from anyone, Sheikh Bahmanpour points out; being brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, so that they understand far more.

The second gift is a different kind of life, promised in Surah al-Nahl to whoever acts righteously, man or woman, while having faith.

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَٰلِحًا مِّن ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهُۥ حَيَوٰةً طَيِّبَةً ۖ

Whoever acts righteously, [whether] male or female, should he be faithful, We shall revive him with a good life

Qur’an 16:97

This good life, *hayat tayyiba*, is in Sheikh Bahmanpour’s reading a clean life. Its people live in the world without being soiled by it, rising above the worries that occupy everyone else. This good life, he says, is what the mystics seek.

The third gift is peace, promised in the verse of Surah Yunus that names the friends of God.

أَلَآ إِنَّ أَوْلِيَآءَ ٱللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Qur’an 10:62

For the muqarrabun, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, the terms are entirely different from those of ordinary believers.

None of this would matter to an ordinary reader if it were reserved for prophets. Surah al-Nisa’ answers that concern.

وَمَن يُطِعِ ٱللَّهَ وَٱلرَّسُولَ فَأُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ مَعَ ٱلَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ ٱللَّهُ عَلَيْهِم مِّنَ ٱلنَّبِيِّـۧنَ وَٱلصِّدِّيقِينَ وَٱلشُّهَدَآءِ وَٱلصَّٰلِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Qur'an 4:69

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads this verse as naming four ranks of those God has blessed: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada'*, which the translation used here renders "martyrs" and which he takes as "the witnesses"; and the righteous (*salihin*). The first three ranks, he says, are beyond us; the fourth is a doorway. The salihin are those able to receive this favour, and from among them God chooses the truthful and the prophets. The way in is righteous action, as the verse on the good life also says.

That doorway is open to people like us: ordinary people, he says, can also enter the realm of the muqarrabun. It is difficult, he says, but it is open, because we are made for it. We call ourselves human beings, yet he says "we are not yet human beings". We begin with the potential to become human in the full sense that the prophets are. He means this as a statement of what we were made for. A human being, he says, has the capacity to become a friend of God; God created us with that capacity, and wants us to reach it.

This is the case for pursuing 'irfan. The Qur'an invites more than the minimum, and what stands in the way is a faculty in us that can be repaired. On the other side of that repair lie nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief. That rank is open to any believer who obeys God and the Prophet and acts righteously.

The aim is God, not powers

Pursuing 'irfan means training the soul, and soul-training is not unique to Islam. People take up the inner life for different reasons. Some train the soul in an attempt to gain power: to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, or to master the hidden world of the soul. Sheikh Bahmanpour says this kind of mysticism must be held apart from the real thing. Islamic mysticism

is about catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and see.

He ended his first lecture more strongly. ‘Irfan “is not about any type of power or empowering the soul” to work *karamat* and *mu‘jizat*, the wonders of the saints and the miracles of the prophets. Then: “These are shirk.” *Shirk*, setting up a partner beside God, is the gravest charge in Islam.

The great teachers of the Shia tradition make closely related points, each in his own words. ‘Allama Tabataba’i tells the traveller that he “has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities”, nor to perform austerities or recite invocations to gain powers such as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others. Whoever does so “does not move on the path of the Beloved’s pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God”. It is his own self that he worships, “though he may not admit it by word of mouth”[8].

> ◈ **WHO'S WHO: ‘ALLAMA TABATABA’I**
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> Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba’i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a commentary on the Qur’an in twenty volumes[9]. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihrani describes him as having flown “with the two wings of knowledge and action”. He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza ‘Ali Aqa Qadi, and after years of philosophical argument he “came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur’an”[10]. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihrani’s record of the lectures on ethics and gnosis that Tabataba’i gave to students in Qum in 1949–50[11]. He also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*[12], from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Imam Khomeini reports the test his teacher Ayatullah Shahabadi used: the measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller’s “spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid”[13].

[8] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 28–29.
[9] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.
[10] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 8.
[11] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 9.
[12] Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.
[13] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

Murtada Mutahhari uses the same word as Sheikh Bahmanpour. The ʻurafa', he writes, consider it "a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one's goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself", and he recalls Imam ʻAli (ʻa) saying that he worshipped God not from fear of His Fire or desire for His Paradise but because he found Him worthy of worship[14].

The scholars differ in emphasis but agree that powers are not the aim. Sheikh Bahmanpour calls such powers shirk. Mutahhari explains why seeking them would be so: the goal has become something other than God.

Seeking, and nothing else

With powers set aside, what remains is the definition Sheikh Bahmanpour gave at the end of his first lecture: ʻirfan "is actually seeking and nothing else". It seeks two things: *maʻrifah*, the knowledge of God; and the love of God.

> ع **WORD STUDY: ʻIRFAN AND MAʻRIFAH**
> *ʻIrfan*, *maʻrifah*, *ʻarif* and its plural *ʻurafa'* belong to one family of words about knowing. An ʻarif, as Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it, is "someone who knows". "Mystic" is used of Christians, Hindus and Buddhists alike; ʻarif is the Islamic word, and it makes a precise claim. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The ʻarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[15]. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (ʻa), says that there is no way to God except through knowledge[16]. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from what we learn from books, is the subject of Chapter 2.

ʻAllama Tabataba'i's definition agrees: "The real gnostic is he who worships Allah not, because he hopes for any reward or is afraid of any punishment, but only because he knows Him and loves Him"[17].

ʻIrfan is therefore worth pursuing: it is the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.

If the aim is to know and love God, what kind of knowing is that?

[14] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.
[15] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.
[16] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʻa), p. 9.
[17] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.

➤ TRY THIS

Sheikh Bahmanpour built his first lesson on the four signs of Surah al-Rum. For one week, read Q 30:21–24 slowly once a day. After each verse, ask yourself what he found in its ending: whether you reflect, whether you know, whether you listen and whether you use your reason. Then, at some point in the day, notice one of the four signs where it occurs in your life: the affection in your home, the languages and colours of the people you meet, your own sleep and the work that earns your living, or the rain.

2

Knowing about God is not knowing Him

On a day of fasting in Ramadan, by late afternoon, no one has to be told that they are hungry. They do not read it in a book or work it out from the clock. The hunger is known from the inside. Sheikh Bahmanpour uses hunger to describe a kind of knowing that differs from the kind gained by study.

Most of what we know of God is of the kind gained by study. We learn the rulings of fiqh, the beliefs the scholars set out and the history of the Prophet ﷺ and the Imams (ʿa); all of it is knowledge about God. Chapter 1 argued that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum, and that the aim is to know and love God. The knowing it means is the kind the fasting person has of their hunger: knowing God, and not only knowing about Him.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *ʿIlm*: knowledge, especially knowledge gained by study · *ʿilm al-husuli*: acquired knowledge · *ʿilm al-huduri*: knowledge by presence · *ʿaql*: the reasoning intellect · *suluk*: wayfaring; the path of purification

Knowing about, and knowing

Let's start with the two kinds of knowing as the philosophers and the mystics divide them. The first is acquired knowledge, *ʿilm al-husuli*. It reaches us from outside, through the senses or by reasoning. We form concepts of the things

around us, then analyse those concepts. Almost everything we learn from teachers and books is of this kind.

Acquired knowledge works by defining its object. To understand a thing, we sort it into a category and mark where it ends and something else begins. The Arabic for a definition, *hadd*, also means a limit. Sheikh Bahmanpour draws the lesson from the word: to define a thing is to limit it. The old definition of a human being as "the rational animal" works by drawing a line round us. This kind of knowledge, he adds, belongs to the realm of time and space.

The second kind is knowledge by presence, *'ilm al-huduri*. It does not come from outside and needs no concept to carry it; it is with the soul already. The plainest case, in the Sheikh's account, is our knowledge of our own self. Hunger, the example this chapter opened with, is another, and so is pain.

Knowledge by presence is complete in a way that acquired knowledge is not. When the body is hungry, the soul knows it at once and without effort, and nothing of the hunger is missed. The hunger may even be false, the Sheikh notes, yet the feeling is real and drives us. Anxiety works in the same way. It has a cause outside us, but the feeling comes from inside the soul; the cause is not the feeling.

This second kind of knowing is what the mystics are after. Sheikh Bahmanpour defines mysticism as the urge to reach out to the infinite through knowledge by presence. The two kinds of knowing therefore aim at different things. *'Ilm*, in his terms, aims at understanding; *ma'rifah* aims at arriving. A person does not try to understand their hunger; they arrive at it and feel it.

Ma'rifah turns inward, and it is bound up with purifying the self. The mystic's aim, the Sheikh says, is to arrive at God and not to define Him, since a God who has been defined has been limited.

The two words are kept apart here only as a working distinction. Sheikh Bahmanpour notes that the religious texts use *'ilm* and *ma'rifah* for the same thing. When they speak of 'ilm they mean ma'rifah; they do not count the other kind as knowledge in the full sense. He separates the words to make the difference between the two kinds of knowing easier to see.

Imam Khomeini records the same line between the two kinds of knowing. In his commentary on a saying of Imam 'Ali ('a), he reports the view that a gnostic of God "knows God through direct witnessing", while a scholar of

God "attains the knowledge of God through philosophical proofs"[18]. The word Imam Khomeini uses for that witnessing, *huduriyya*, shares its root with *ʿilm al-huduri*. The gnostic's knowledge of God is knowledge by presence.

Murtada Mutahhari draws the contrast himself, with an image from the sciences. The philosopher's knowledge, he writes, is like that of a mathematician who has thought a problem through. The knowledge sought by the ʿarif "is experienced and witnessed", like the knowledge a scientist gains in his laboratory[19]. A result in the laboratory is known because it has been observed, not because it has been deduced.

> ع **WORD STUDY: ʿILM AL-HUSULI AND ʿILM AL-HUDURI**
> *Husul* means acquiring or obtaining; *hudur* means presence. In *ʿilm al-husuli*, acquired knowledge, what reaches the mind is a concept or an image of the thing, while the thing itself stays outside. Sheikh Bahmanpour's example is an object in front of him: there is a picture of it in his mind, and the picture is there because of the object. In *ʿilm al-huduri*, knowledge by presence, the thing known is itself present to the soul, as our own self, our hunger and our pain are present. Chapter 1's Word Study noted that there is no way to God except through knowledge, and left open what kind of knowledge that is. The ʿarif's knowledge of God is of the second kind.

Where reason stops

Acquired knowledge is the work of reason, *ʿaql*, the theoretical intellect by which we reason, understand and argue. Reason has a limit, and Sheikh Bahmanpour says where it lies. When we know a thing, we know its attributes: its colour, its size, what it does. Reason does not reach the thing that carries those attributes. Every description says that it is brown or square or useful, and none says what the "it" is.

In the Sheikh's account, Ibn Sina, the master of the philosophers, granted this. To know the reality of a thing, he held, is beyond human capacity; what we know of an object is its characteristics and attributes. If this is true of the things around us, it is true far more of God. God has no colour, no dimension and no function for the mind to take hold of.

[18]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 542.
[19]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 41.

STORY: IBN SINA AND ABU SAʿID

Sheikh Bahmanpour tells how Ibn Sina changed after he met Abu Saʿid Abu'l-Khayr, a great mystic of his time. As a young man Ibn Sina had no rival among the philosophers. Towards the end of his life, the Sheikh says, he wrote to Abu Saʿid asking to learn from him. In his *al-Isharat wa'l-Tanbihat* he then wrote a section on the stations of the ʿarifs, which the teachers of ʿirfan in Qum still teach and regard as unsurpassed. The Sheikh does not count Ibn Sina an ʿarif; his mind was bright enough to write that section from a visit and a correspondence. His remark that the reality of things is beyond human capacity came before he wrote that section. Murtada Mutahhari also records that the two men met[20]. He summarises the same section of the *Isharat*, and calls Ibn Sina "mainly a philosopher, not a mystic", though one who "especially towards the end of his life … developed mystic inclinations"[21].

Imam ʿAli (ʿa) makes the same point about God at the opening of the first oration in *Nahj al-Balagha*, where he praises Him.

> *Soaring thoughts cannot reach him and deep minds cannot fathom him.*[22]
>
> Nahj al-Balagha

Soaring and depth are the two strengths of reason, its range and its penetration, and the Imam says that neither arrives at God. The next sentence of the oration gives the reason. God "cannot be described, for he is beyond the limits of demarcated boundaries"[23]. Sheikh Bahmanpour cites *Nahj al-Balagha* for the same point, that whoever defines God has placed limits on Him.

Reason is not left with nothing to do. Arguments can show that God exists, the Sheikh says, but they cannot say what God is. It might seem to follow that nothing can be known of Him at all. Sheikh Bahmanpour does not draw that conclusion. "We cannot know the essence of God and we cannot understand God," he says. "But we want to know Him." ʿIrfan, he goes on, wants to know God's primordial attributes and His eternal characteristics.

[20] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 29.
[21] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.
[22] Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.
[23] Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.

This knowledge of God's attributes is positive, and the Sheikh sets it against the negative kind. Much of what we know about God is negative: God is not a body, and God is not in one place and absent from another. Such statements are true; each says what God is not. The prophets, he says, were after something else. They wanted a real experience and knowledge of God, "a positive and not a negative knowledge".

That positive knowledge is not reached by analysis. In ʿirfan, the Sheikh says, it comes from the illumination of the heart, and it "could be actually grasped by the soul". Knowledge by presence ordinarily covers only our own states, he grants; of things outside us, knowledge has to be acquired. The way to knowing God by presence therefore runs through the soul's knowledge of itself, the subject of Chapter 4. The prophets knew God in this way, with a knowledge present in their hearts and not worked out by argument.

> ◈ **WHO'S WHO: MULLA SADRA**
>
> In Sheikh Bahmanpour's account, Mulla Sadra changed the whole course of Islamic philosophy. He moved it from the Peripatetic philosophy, *al-hikma al-mashshaʾiyya*, to what is called the transcendent philosophy, *al-hikma al-mutaʿaliya*. For Mulla Sadra, the Sheikh says, the reality of things can be known only by the soul, through knowledge by presence, and this is the only way to know God. *Kernel of the Kernels* calls him Sadr al-Muta'allihin Shirazi, "the pride of the philosophers of the East". It records that after a lifetime in philosophy he asked God's pardon for the years spent on "the pseudo-philosophers and polemicists from among the theologians", until "it became clear to me that their syllogisms were barren and their path devoid of straightness"[24]. He then surrendered his affairs to God and His Messenger, and followed the Prophet's guidance without looking for a rational justification for it[25].

Light in the heart

Knowledge that analysis cannot produce has to come from somewhere else. Sheikh Bahmanpour names the source with a hadith on knowledge, which Imam Khomeini also quotes in his *Forty Hadith*.

[24] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 7.
[25] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 7.

Knowledge is not extensive learning. Rather, it is a light that God casts in the heart of whomever He wills.[26]

Hadith

The hadith sets the two kinds of knowing side by side. Extensive learning is acquired knowledge, gathered from outside. The light is not gathered at all; God places it in the heart. The *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (ʿa), uses nearly the same words. Knowledge, it says, is a light "which Allah casts into the heart of whomsoever He wills"[27].

The words "whomever He wills" might suggest that God keeps His light for a chosen few. Sheikh Bahmanpour speaks of the light differently, and he does so with a verse of Surah al-Nur.

ٱللَّهُ نُورُ ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ ۚ

Allah is the Light of the heavens and the earth.

Qur'an 24:35

Allah's light, the Sheikh says, is everywhere, in the heavens and in the earth, and He is with us wherever we are. It is the heart that is closed. It is not the case, he says, that Allah picks out some people to receive light and passes over others. There is no hindrance on His side to pouring His knowledge and bounty upon us. His knowledge and bounty are all there; the work of the 'urafa' is to open the heart and let the light in.

Imam Khomeini makes the same point in his comment on the hadith of light. There is, he writes, "no niggardliness in the higher realms", which give of their nature[28]. Whatever stands between the heart and the light stands on our side. The light, the Sheikh says, comes to the hearts of the pure, and darkness covers the impure. Chapter 1 reached the same conclusion by another road, when it placed the fault in the receiver.

A light placed in one heart can reach another, and this, for Sheikh Bahmanpour, is how the knowledge of the 'urafa' travels. We know from experience how knowledge passes from one mind to another, through speech

[26] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.
[27] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari'a), p. 10.
[28] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

and writing; we have no such experience of knowledge passing from one heart to another. The knowledge of the ʿurafa', he says, nonetheless passes in the second way, coming "not from mind to mouth but from heart" to heart.

This light usually reaches a traveller through another heart. Receiving it directly from God is possible, the ʿurafa' say, but it is difficult; most travellers need someone else to begin. In Shia belief, the Sheikh adds, whatever knowledge of God we receive comes from the Imam (ʿa). It reaches the heart through him, even when we do not realise it.

The path is purification

If the light is everywhere and the heart is closed, the path to knowing God is the opening of the heart. Sheikh Bahmanpour sets two words against each other. The knowledge learned at a university or a seminary comes through *fikr*, thought: we think, put things together, analyse and find out. Knowledge of God comes through *suluk*, wayfaring, which he describes as the path to purity, a striving towards purification.

The knowledge of ʿirfan, the Sheikh says, is not something one can read anywhere or work out, and that is why it comes through suluk. In his words, "You purify yourself and then wait for Allah to put the light in your heart." The sentence divides the work. Purification is the traveller's part; the light is Allah's to give.

The first step of purification is to polish the soul by doing whatever the Prophet ﷺ has asked; "without this", the Sheikh says, "there is no maʿrifah". Purification, in his account, is polishing the soul so that it starts working. It is the repair of the rusted faculty that Chapter 1 described.

Having done this, the traveller waits for Allah's help and looks to nothing else. The Sheikh points to the verse of Surah al-Anfal that calls the believers to answer Allah and the Apostle when he summons them to what will give them life (Q 8:24). That life comes, he says, when a person follows the Prophet completely and then waits for the help of Allah.

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah ties the light to the path in one line.

إِنَّ مَنِ ٱنْتَهَجَ بِكَ لَمُسْتَنِيرٌ

One who follows Your path is enlightened.[29]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

The prologue opened on a line from this prayer that asks for the eyes of the heart to be lit until they reach the source of God's grandeur. This line names who receives that light: the one who follows God's path.

A path that is not thought alone leaves open what study is for. Three of the great teachers of the tradition speak to how fikr and suluk relate. For Imam Khomeini and 'Allama Tabataba'i, study prepares the ground for purification, though it cannot take its place.

Imam Khomeini puts little store by mere knowledge. A learning that does not bring faith with it, he writes, "is the greatest of veils". He adds that "one has to approach a veil in order to tear it into shreds"[30]. The sciences, he goes on, are seeds of spiritual experience; the usual way is first to learn of God, His names and His attributes, then to open the heart through exercises and austerities[31]. In another place he gives the view of those who know the subject, that such preliminaries "prepare the soul for receiving knowledge through inspiration"[32].

'Allama Tabataba'i, in the lectures recorded in *Kernel of the Kernels*, gives learning a fixed place near the start. Once the traveller has set out, the first essential, he says, is knowledge of the rules of the shari'a, learned from a jurist. The traveller then puts that knowledge into practice and perseveres until conviction and gnosis grow by degrees. "For knowledge gives birth to action and action in turn brings knowledge"[33]. In his scheme, what is learned from the jurist begins the circle, and the deeper knowledge comes back from the practice.

Murtada Mutahhari, the third, separates the philosopher from the 'arif by the means each uses. The philosopher works with reason, deductions and

[29]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §88.

[30]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 403.

[31]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 403.

[32]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

[33]'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 56.

proofs. The means of the ‘arif, he writes, are “the heart and the purification, disciplining and perfecting of the self”[34]. His list starts with the heart, and every item after it is a form of purification.

Knowing by drawing near

Those brought near to God, the ‘urafa’, know Him in the second way, through a veil removed and not a definition learned. Their knowing is present to the soul, as hunger is present to the one who fasts, and it comes as a light that God places in a purified heart.

Knowing God therefore differs in kind from knowing about God. It is reached by purification; study, in the view of Imam Khomeini and ‘Allama Tabataba’i, serves it but cannot replace it.

Where, then, does an ordinary believer already stand on this path?

> **TRY THIS**
>
> In every prostration of the daily prayer we say, “Glory belongs to my Lord, the Exalted, and Him do I praise.” ‘Allama Tabataba’i uses these words to show how knowledge follows action[35]. For one week, in one prayer each day, say them slowly, “believing it to be a fact”. Notice your own lowliness with your forehead on the ground, then the majesty of the One you are calling exalted. From “a very minor action, such as this dhikr said in prostration”, he says, a person comes to discover God’s absolute majesty[36].

[34] Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.

[35] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 56–57.

[36] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 57.

3

You already know these words

وَّقَلْبِي بِحُبِّكَ مُتَيَّماً

And my heart enthralled by Your love![37]

Du'a Kumayl

These words come near the end of Du'a Kumayl, the prayer Imam 'Ali ('a) taught to Kumayl ibn Ziyad, one of his closest disciples. The Mafatih al-Jinan recommends it on every Thursday evening, the night before Friday, when many of us hear it[38]. The line asks God for a heart enthralled by His love.

A request for God's love begins to answer the question Chapter 2 ended on. That chapter argued that knowing God is reached by purifying the heart, and it asked where an ordinary believer already stands on this path. The words we already say ask for exactly what Chapter 2 described. Du'a Kumayl asks for the love that goes with that knowing; other prayers we recite ask for the knowing itself. This chapter sets out what those prayers ask for.

[37] *Du'a Kumayl* (duas.org), §221.

[38] Shaykh 'Abbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *duʿa*: supplication, any request made to God · *munajat*: an intimate, whispered prayer to God · *Mafatih al-Jinan*: the standard manual of Shia prayers · *inqitaʿ*: severance of the heart from all but God

Cut off from all else

Let's start with the order in which the prayers ask. Sheikh Bahmanpour reads the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah as a sequence. Those who seek God, he says, want to know Him and to look at Him, but "they have to cut off from everything first". In the prayer, the request for light in the eyes of the heart, with which this book opened, follows straight on from a request to be cut off.

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي كَمَالَ ٱلِانْقِطَاعِ إِلَيْكَ

My Lord, grant me complete severance of my relations with everything else[39]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The Arabic word for this severance is *inqitaʿ*, being cut off, and the Munajat asks for it complete. Sheikh Bahmanpour asks whether it is good to be cut off completely from everything else. In the heart, he answers, it is. He places this severance a step beyond the sensitivity to God's signs that Chapter 1 described.

The severance the prayers ask for is therefore in the heart, not in the household or the marketplace. It is the severance Chapter 1 found in the friends of God, who keep their families and their place in society while their hearts are cut off from everything else.

Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali makes the Munajat's request in its own way, naming the attachment it wants removed. "O my Master, (please) expel love for the world out of my heart," it asks (سَيِّدِي أَخْرِجْ حُبَّ ٱلدُّنْيَا مِنْ قَلْبِي).[40] What the prayer asks to lose is the heart's love for the world, not the world itself or the people and the work in it.

Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, describes the same severance from the other side, as something God has already done for those He loves.

[39] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §104.

[40] *Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §384.

وَأَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَزَلْتَ ٱلأَغْيَارَ عَنْ قُلُوبِ أَحِبَّائِكَ حَتَّىٰ لَمْ يُحِبُّوا سِوَاكَ

It is You Who have removed love for others from the hearts of Your lovers so that they have loved none save You[41]

Duʿa ʿArafah

The line names God as the one who cleared these hearts. He removed love for others from them, and what remained was love for Him alone.

To see, to love, to draw near

A heart cleared of everything but God is free for Him. The prayers go on to ask for three things: to see God with the heart, to love Him, and to come near Him. Let's take them in turn.

The first is sight, the subject of the Munajat's petition for light in the eyes of the heart. Sheikh Bahmanpour explains why the request is made of the heart. The eyes in our heads work, and still we miss the signs, because the faculty behind them is blind. The prayer asks God to give that inner eye light to see by.

The same petition asks that these eyes pass through the veils of light. The mystics speak of veils of light and darkness that the heart must pass through, and Sheikh Bahmanpour notes that people unfamiliar with such words sometimes take them for mistakes. The phrase comes from the Munajat itself.

Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, speaks of the heart's light as something God has already given to some.

أَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَشْرَقْتَ ٱلأَنْوَارَ فِي قُلُوبِ أَوْلِيَائِكَ

It is You Who have lit the illuminations in the hearts of Your intimate servants[42]

Duʿa ʿArafah

The word translated "Your intimate servants" is *awliya'*, the friends of God whom Chapter 1 met in Surah Yunus. Chapter 2 described knowledge of God

[41] Imam al-Husayn, *Du'a 'Arafah* (duas.org), §783–784.
[42] Imam al-Husayn, *Du'a 'Arafah* (duas.org), §781.

as a light that God places in a heart that has been purified. This line says where He has placed it, in the hearts of His friends.

The second request is love. The Munajat asks for a place among God's friends, and it defines that place by love.

إِلٰهِي أَقِمْنِي فِي أَهْلِ وِلايَتِكَ مُقَامَ مَنْ رَجَا ٱلزِّيَادَةَ مِنْ مَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, place me among Your friends in the position of one who hopes for an increase in Your love.[43]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads the friendship asked for here, *wilaya*, as having two parts. One is ma'rifah: understanding God, looking at Him, knowing Him. The other is love for Him. In his reading neither is fixed; the love is incessant, and the ma'rifah keeps increasing. These are the two aims Chapter 1 gave 'irfan, and the Sheikh finds both in one line of the Munajat.

The third request is nearness, and the Munajat makes it earlier in the same prayer.

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي قَلْباً يُدْنِيهِ مِنْكَ شَوْقُهُ

My Lord, provide me with a heart, the passion of which may bring it near You[44]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

In this request the heart is brought near by its own passion for God. Du'a Abu Hamza al-Thumali goes further and asks to love the meeting with God itself. "O Lord of Glory and Honor, (please do) make me love meeting You," it says (يَا ذَا ٱلْجَلَالِ وَٱلإِكْرَامِ حَبِّبْ إِلَيَّ لِقَاءَكَ.)[45]

The Whispered Prayer of the Lovers asks for a place among those who have already been brought near. It is one of the fifteen whispered prayers

[43]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §92–93.

[44]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §82.

[45]*Du'a Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §599.

printed with the Sahifa, and Sheikh Bahmanpour read several of its lines to his listeners.

My God, place us with him whom Thou hast chosen for Thy nearness and Thy friendship, ... granted gazing upon Thy face[46]

Whispered Prayer of the Lovers

For some of us, the Sheikh says, calling on God can feel like calling into the sky to someone far away. For some, God is present when they call, and they feel His response. The prayer asks to be placed with these: among those chosen for His nearness, and granted the sight of His face.

Murtada Mutahhari names these prayers together in his introduction to ʿirfan. "The Du'a' Kumayl, the Du'a' Abi Hamzah, the supplications of al-Sahifat al-Kamilah and the group of supplications called Sha'baniyyah," he writes, "all contain the most sublime spiritual ideas"[47]. He cites them to show that ʿirfan has its sources inside Islam, with no need to look for its origin elsewhere.

A pupil reading above his level

Requests this high raise a difficulty, and Sheikh Bahmanpour states it himself. These words, he says, belong to the peak of the understanding and longing of the *muqarrabun*, those brought near to God. He asks why we are told to recite them at all. Telling ordinary believers to say them, he says, is "like [telling] a primary school boy to read books of university".

The prayers themselves speak from need, as a pupil would. Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, offers God one thing as its means of approach, the supplicant's need of Him.

هَا أَنَا أَتَوَسَّلُ إِلَيْكَ بِفَقْرِي إِلَيْكَ

Here I am begging You by my need for You.[48]

Duʿa ʿArafah

[46] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 656.
[47] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 20.
[48] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §689.

Du'a Abu Hamza al-Thumali makes the same plea from need, and places the one who prays at a door. "O my Master, I, Your servant, am standing at Your door owing to neediness," it says (سَيِّدِي عَبْدُكَ بِبَابِكَ أَقَامَتْهُ ٱلْخَصَاصَةُ بَيْنَ يَدَيْكَ)[49]. The servant stands there because of need, and the prayer gives no other reason for coming.

The line at the head of Part One takes this humility further. In it the Munajat admits that the one reciting had no strength to move away from disobedience "except when You awakened me to Your love"[50]. In this line, even the turning towards God is His doing.

Sheikh Bahmanpour's answer to his own question rests on the same humility. We do not understand many of the meanings of these words, he says, and they are not of our level or within our capacity. Not understanding them does not make them meaningless. We have been honoured, because we are allowed to recite them. In his account, God invites the reciter to come and say them; if the reciter is sincere, God may grant the request. What the Imams asked for, the Sheikh adds, God granted them.

ع WORD STUDY: DU'A AND MUNAJAT

Du'a is the general word for supplication: any request addressed to God, in any words. A *munajat* is one kind of du'a. The Mafatih's English calls the Munajat Sha'baniyyah a "confidential prayer"[51], and William Chittick translates the fifteen munajat printed with the Sahifa as "whispered prayers"[52]. Both translations describe speech meant for God alone. Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi explains why the Imams' supplications reach further than their other words. In their narrations they spoke with people; in their supplications they spoke with God, and the level of speech depends on the understanding of the one addressed. The Qur'an, he writes, is a "Descending-Qur'an", God's words to His servants. The supplications are an "Ascending-Qur'an", the words of His most distinguished servants rising towards Him[53].

[49] *Du'a Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §510.
[50] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 164.
[51] Shaykh 'Abbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.
[52] Imam Zayn al-'Abidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 9.
[53] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 43.

Prayers for ordinary nights

God's invitation to recite these words comes through books that ordinary believers already use. Four of the prayers quoted in this chapter are in the Mafatih al-Jinan, the standard manual of Shia devotion[54]. The Mafatih sets each of them on a night or a day in the believer's year.

> ⧗ **HISTORY: THE MAFATIH AND THE SAHIFA**
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> The *Mafatih al-Jinan*, "Keys to the Heavens", gathers the supplications of the Imams, the words to be recited at particular times, and the forms for visiting the Imams' shrines. Its compiler, Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, was a scholar of vast learning who died in Najaf in 1359/1940[55]. Al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya is far older. William Chittick calls it "the oldest prayer manual in Islamic sources", composed by Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (ʿa), the fourth Imam; Shia tradition ranks it behind only the Qur'an and Nahj al-Balagha[56]. The Imam died in Medina in 95/713–4, or a year earlier[57]. The fifteen whispered prayers, the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers among them, were added to several modern editions of the Sahifa. They seem to have reached most Shia through ʿAllama Muhammad Baqir Majlisi, the compiler of *Bihar al-Anwar*[58].

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah is listed among the acts of the month of Shaʿban. The Mafatih gives a report that calls it the confidential prayer of Imam ʿAli (ʿa) and the Imams, which they used to say in that month[59]. It adds that it is "advisable to say it with presence of heart all the time"[60].

The other prayers have their own times. Duʿa Kumayl belongs to Thursday evenings and to the night of mid-Shaʿban[61]. Duʿa ʿArafah is the prayer of Imam al-Husayn (ʿa) on the Day of ʿArafah[62]. Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali belongs to Ramadan. Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (ʿa) said it in the last hour of the month's

[54] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.
[55] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.
[56] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 7.
[57] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 8.
[58] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 9.
[59] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.
[60] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.
[61] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.
[62] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 374.
[63] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 282.

nights[63]. Maliki Tabrizi tells the traveller not to forget it, every night or every other night[64].

Imam Khomeini, in one of his talks, takes this familiarity for granted. "You are already familiar with the words used in Imams' supplications," he tells his listeners, before reading them lines from the Shaʿbaniyyah[65].

Familiarity with the words is not the same as reaching what they describe, and the scholars say so. Maliki Tabrizi, having called the supplications an Ascending-Qur'an, writes that this "is not accepted and comprehended by any one, except a small number of believers who are thoroughly familiar and enlightened"[66]. Imam Khomeini makes a narrower point. On one hard question, how to put God's relation to His creation into words, he says that "those who are fit to do so" should pray in the style of the Shaʿbaniyyah for God to enlighten them[67].

Sheikh Bahmanpour still recommends the Munajat to every listener, to be recited in Shaʿban as often as they can, while granting that we do not understand many of its meanings. The two positions answer different questions. The scholars speak of how far a reciter reaches; the Sheikh speaks of who may begin. What this chapter claims is access to these words, rather than attainment of what they ask for.

Words already on our lips

Access to these words is where an ordinary believer already stands on the path. Part One began with the Qur'an's invitation to more than the minimum. Chapter 2 showed that the more is knowing God, not only knowing about Him, reached by purifying the heart. This chapter has found that knowing, with the love that goes with it, in prayers believers already say.

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, Duʿa Kumayl, Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali and Duʿa ʿArafah ask God to cut the heart off from all else, to light it, to fill it with His love and to bring it near. They ask in the voice of someone in need, on nights the ordinary believer keeps. The goal of ʿirfan is therefore not

[64] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 111.
[65] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 156.
[66] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 43.
[67] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 157.

foreign to the believer: it is already on our lips. The full text of the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, in Arabic and English, is given in the Appendix.

These prayers keep asking God to work on the heart and the self. What is this self?

> **➤ TRY THIS**
>
> Sheikh Bahmanpour built part of his first lecture on the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah. This week, read its petitions from §82 to §111 (in the Appendix) once, slowly, with the English beside the Arabic. The Mafatih advises saying the prayer "with presence of heart"[68]. As you read, notice the requests this chapter has followed: to be cut off from all else, to see, to love and to draw near. When Shaʿban comes, follow the Sheikh's own advice and recite the whole prayer "as much as you can".

[68] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.